

Book review forum: *Lively Cities: Reconfiguring Urban Ecology* (2023) by Maan Barua

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Enacting the City Otherwise

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In 2020, the SARS-CoV-2 virus fundamentally reshaped the lives of millions of people around the world. This was especially true in urban areas where we live in close proximity to each other. As we scrambled to adjust our daily habits to slow down the spread of the disease caused by the virus, the Covid-19 pandemic prompted novel infrastructural forms almost overnight. Perhaps the most obvious example was the expansion of healthcare facilities, including the repurposing of entire stadiums as testing and vaccination sites. But other more quotidian infrastructural forms also emerged: from the practice of organizing “pods” as a way to maintain a sense of sociality, to the revalorization of parks and other public outdoors spaces. While everyone’s experiences were different according to their privileges, or lack thereof, what is clear is that the urban was reconfigured by a tiny nanoscopic virus in its ecological relation with humans as an infectious disease. The pandemic made evident that other-than-human beings, too, produce the urban. Yet, this simple fact has been neglected in canonical urban theory due to its persistent inclination to overlook other-than-human agency.

In a necessary intervention, Maan Barua’s *Lively Cities: Reconfiguring Urban Ecology* demonstrates how ecological relations between human and other-than-human city dwellers shape the urban. Importantly, the book is not about a seismic event like a global pandemic, but about ordinary ecologies of animal urbanites. The book illustrates that, whether hostile or hospitable to their presence, animals interpret urban designs and improvise to adjust their habits; it shows how the daily rhythms of animal life in the city affect people, and how these affective relations prompt particular infrastructural forms. Attention to the everyday is key because such infrastructural forms are always in the making. Here, the notion of infrastructure moves beyond the built environment to include heterogeneous social and economic assemblages and is always open-ended. By bringing to the fore the

livelihoods of rhesus macaques and cows in Delhi, parakeets in London, and their respective human commensals, Barua reveals that cities are living formations co-produced in quotidian encounters among species. Seen in this light, the city becomes alive.

How to foreground the aliveness of the city when, so far, major theories and practices tend to view the world, urban or not, as a container where living beings *take*, but do not *make*, place? Barua proposes a “wider ontology” of the urban (p. 5), one that highlights the makeshift, beastly everyday making of urban worlds, in the plural. To attend to this plurality, the author develops an analytical gaze tuned in a minor key. The minor, Barua explains, refers to modes of expression that groups in minoritarian positions produce in the language of majoritarian subjects (p. 14). Instead of majoritarian subjects, however, the book examines and aims to unsettle majoritarian logics governing (or attempting to govern) city life: first, anthropocentrism, as the urban is imagined as a space built exclusively through human agency; second, hylomorphism, or the idea that passive materials and matter take infrastructural forms imposed by human designs; third, a teleological view of urban development, or the presumption of a progressive path toward “planetary urbanization” (p. 192); and fourth, a tendency to overemphasize economic relations over ecological, cultural, and affective ones. As anything and anyone illegible, refusing, or exceeding major visions of the urban is treated as a problem, or worse, rendered non-existent, a minor key brings to the spotlight those troubling subjects and their livelihoods on their own terms. Unencumbered from the restrictions imposed by majoritarian logics, the minor exposes real alternatives to this set of problematic assumptions about the city. As Cindi Katz (2017) puts it, “thinking in a minor key opens many spaces of betweenness from which to imagine, act, and live things differently” (p. 597).

Barua contributes to minor theory (cf. Katz, 1996) by foregrounding the minor as existing material practices. Through rich ethnographies paired with archival research, the book analyzes a back and forth between minor and major urban practices in Delhi and London—two cities intertwined by colonial histories. For instance, in majoritarian logics, the agrarian is considered a formation that predates, and therefore does not belong in, the city. The book shows how cattle grazing and dairy operations are urban practices that persist in Delhi in spite of city officials’ decades-long efforts to displace them outside the city boundaries. In this way, we see minor ecologies emerging in the interstices of master plans as cracks in infrastructure. Crucially, each crack is unique; an agrarian urban formation will look very different elsewhere. While “major practices are everywhere, [minor] vernacular practices are here” (p. 92). Situated in many “heres,” the minor reveals a plurality of visions of the city, which means a plurality of ways to live and make the urban. However, things are not as simple as visualizing alternatives and then choosing to act differently. Barua constantly reminds us that, because the minor always exists in relation to the major, the analysis of minor ecologies requires contextualizing practices within broader struggles for power.

What I find most compelling in *Lively Cities* is that it thrives in messiness. Barua deploys a sharp political economic analysis of urban co-habitation as a bridge between posthuman and postcolonial studies to ground the material politics of commensalism, ferality, and pastoralism in the city. A key point advanced in Barua’s argument is that, when considering the messy histories of extraction, travel, domesticity, escape, and ferality of animals captured for the global pet trade, circuits of capital can be seen as evolutionary events that “run geologic history backwards” (p. 130). The phylogeographies of parakeet populations in London—introduced as a commodity now going feral—manifest as rhizomatic, novel “braided lines [of descent], in that the tracks of birds of different origins interweave and intertwine” (p. 129). When thinking with ferality, in all its messiness, the urban is revealed as recombinant. But ferality is not politically neutral. Urban parakeets in London inspire a variety of responses, from delighted crowds routinely gathering to feed them, to nativist, xenophobic anxieties projected onto the birds.

Methodologically, the book advances multispecies ethnographies. Instead of striving to be a participant observer, the researcher retreats as a spectator of how animals observe human behavior before

becoming themselves participants. Moreover, Barua highlights the materials that bind humans and animals and that are crucial for urban ecologies: the electric grid, waste and waste facilities, bird feed and feeders, concrete, and so on. This kind of ethnographic commitment affords a productive analysis of social hierarchies present in heterogeneous assemblages of humans, other-than-humans, and materials, which helps us grasp the politics of multispecies co-habitation beyond the recognition of more-than-human agency.

The book advances arguments by mobilizing concepts from a wide variety of intellectual traditions. While the work of building theoretical bridges across fields is an important contribution, the book at times feels too abstract. For instance, the author deploys Deleuze and Guattari's concept of "lines of flight" to illustrate the "diagonal movements" of parakeets as they escape out from the circuits of capital into ferality: "To fly off the grid of capital is to have neither a wild nor a commodity life, but rather to take [. . .] a pathway deterritorializing lively capital to produce non-binary life courses and a non-arborescent urban world" (p. 124). This concept seems useful in destabilizing binary notions like wild/domestic and native/introduced species, but I wished for further clarification about the original conceptualization of "lines of flight," how the concept travels across objects of study, and why is it suitable to think about ferality as a deterritorialized escape from capital.

Because our modes of thinking are deeply material (cf. Haraway, 2016), the conceptual interventions empirically sustained in *Lively Cities* provide the reader with a series of tools to think and enact the city otherwise. The book is thoroughly situated within urban, economic, and animal geographies, but its insights generate several avenues of conversation with anyone invested in the study of more-than-human life. Fields like political ecology, environmental anthropology, multispecies studies, critical agrarian studies, and ecocriticism will find valuable conceptualizations in this book. On a practical level, as climate change-induced events like global pandemics, heat waves, flash floods, and wildfires become ordinary, recognizing the liveliness of the urban will be a productive point of departure for thinking and making the city more liveable.

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The Woodworm's-Eye View

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[W]e had the whole of the animal kingdom on board. . . . A certain level of scrutiny was inevitable, and we accepted double-peg locks, stall inspections, a nightly curfew. But regrettably there were also punishments and isolation cells. Someone at the very top became obsessed with information gathering; and certain of the travellers agreed to act as stool pigeons. I'm sorry to report that ratting to the authorities was at times widespread. It wasn't a nature reserve, that Ark of ours; at times it was more like a prison ship (Barnes, 2009: 4).

In Julian Barnes's wonderful short story, "The Stowaway," the story of Noah's Ark is narrated by a woodworm, a decidedly other-than-human,¹ one of seven who managed to smuggle themselves on to the Ark. Woodworms had not been chosen by Noah as appropriate passengers, fearing the consequences of too much wood being eaten, although as it happened the woodworms ate comparatively little. In fact, the majority of the eating on the Ark was done by the humans, so much so that many species initially gathered on the ship—"clean" or "unclean" by Old Testament reckoning—were

Table 1. Barua's binaries.

Criticized	Preferred
majoritarian (major urban grammar)	minoritarian (minor urban grammar)
molar	molecular
macro-politics (biopolitics)	micro-politics (lively politics)
state	vernacular
colonial city/settler city	postcolonial city/nomadic city
formality/order	informality/meshwork
scripting/inscription	improvising/(thick) description
"building"	"dwelling"
"striating"	"smoothing"
environments	ecumenes
enclosures	commons
spacing bodies	bodies in space
"animal spaces"	"beastly places"

"scoffed" (p. 14) by Noah and his family, leaving curious gaps in the supposed evolutionary-development pantheon of non-human life. As the woodworm-narrator makes plain, the humans running the Ark ("at the very top") were for the most part tyrannical in what they ate, in the "exterminatory policy with cross-breeds" (p. 26) and in how they organized and policed the spaces on board. The wiser animals warned their less-intelligent co-voyagers (particularly the sheep and cattle) *not* to succumb to Noah's plea for them to stay close, proximate to human settlement, once dry land was reached. The woodworm clearly discerned that the Ark, this floating city of all the animals, was less "nature reserve" (cared for by Noah the great "conservationist") and more "prison ship" (run by Noah the gaoler, farmer, slaughterer, cook and supreme carnivore).

Maan Barua's fabulous recent book, *Lively Cities* (Barua, 2023), addresses the city, this ark of humans and animals all tumbled together, in an effort to craft a fresh perspective on the city, on urbanity and even "planetary urbanism," that takes seriously from the get-go the heterogenous multiplicity of beings that bring the city to life. No longer centralizing the usual agents of urban world-making, Barua emphasizes how "other-than-human life bursts into presence amid the clamour of urban routine" (p. 1), not just as raw materials on which the human works to create the urban, to build and run it, but as co-dwellers and often highly active co-creators doing much more than just scurrying in the shadows or swooping overhead. Dissenting from the "major key" in which the city is usually written by academics and others, spying instead an as yet little heard "minor key," he explores at length the "non-hylomorphic urban grammar" (p. 276)—not assuming that form, structure and organization are what give shape to matter, but rather the reverse—enacted "as materials respond to questions asked of them by a suite of interlocutors, be they human or other-than-human" (p. 277). Working with "new composites or thought and method" (p. 276), Barua probes diverse "onto-cartographies of the urban" as they get "opened up to a retinue of more-than-human beings, entities and forces" (p. 5). The city-ark is hence rocked back and forth on the stormy seas of speculative critical thought and creative methodological *bricolage*.

Indeed, Barua quarries diverse seams of poststructuralist thought that variously query the totalisations or foundationalisms of much that passes for social and urban theory, identifying a suite of shifting onto-epistemological binaries concerning what kinds of knowledge are being composed about what kinds of objects (or matters). Drawing from his text, if extrapolating a little in places, my Table 1 offers a possible listing of the binaries under scrutiny here. Preferring to thread his way down the right-hand side of my table, Barua claims to be disclosing a lively city where—if patchily and haltingly—generative "outsides" to the lumbering logics of capital, biopolitics, and techno-determinism can be discerned. There are moments when the resulting brew feels almost too rich, as conceptual salvos rain

down and evocative terminologies proliferate, leaving the reader somewhat giddy as they are hurried from one vantage-point on the city to another. Yet, thanks to skilful, often delightful, writing, punctuated by the leaps of macaques, the squawks of parakeets, and the wandering of cattle,² always backgrounded by the teeming worlds of Delhi and London,³ Barua's cities remain lively places inviting to visit rather than the deadening abstractions of much urban-social theory.

At the foot of my table, I have suggested "animal spaces—beastly places" as another axis along which *Lively Cities* operates, recalling a distinction that lightly organized the 2000 collection that I co-edited (Philo and Wilbert, 2000), where "animal spaces" equate with the socio-spatial orderings imposed on animals *by* humans and "beastly places" with the place-making *of* animals left to their own devices. But such an alignment is not quite right, as Barua (2023) explicitly acknowledges:

My use of striations and ecumenes resonates with what geographers call animal spaces, or the abstract spaces in which animals are fixed through classifications, systems, and tables, and beastly places, or other spaces forged by animals through "their own 'beastly' ways, ends, doings, joys and sufferings." However, *contra* beastly places, ecumenes are not solely bound to the animal's own world; rather, they are forged through conjoint relations of the bovine body in a force field that includes people, materials, and infrastructure (pp. 195–196).

Deploying a Deleuze-and-Guattarian sense of "topologies" to disrupt any simple "bipolar" picture here, Barua's emphasis throughout is on the "meshworks" of humans *and* other-than-humans, with the urban that he wishes to envisage, even on the right-hand side of the table, as always about the two sets of beings *together*. If there is an impulse in certain quarters of the "new" animal geographies literature toward a shifting of the dial *from* humans *to* animals (Kathryn et al., 2024; Urbanik et al., 2024), even a secretive longing to purge animal geographies—as academic subfield; as worldly reality—of the human presence, then that is *not* Barua's project in *Lively Cities*.⁴ Indeed, as he states, "[d]iscursive tendencies of urban animal geographies, while situating animals within fields of power, sometimes fall short of articulating a material politics of urban life" (p. 12).

That said, it might be responded that Barua risks neglecting the more hard-edged critical edge of animal geographies (Gillespie and Collard, 2015), vegan geographies, and anarchist political ecologies (Hodge et al., 2022; Springer et al., 2021), wherein the centrality of animal deaths beyond number at the hands of humans—chiefly for food but also for many other extractionist ends—remains foregrounded. Eating is far from neglected in *Lively Cities*, not least because its key conceptual innovation is to introduce "commensality" as a generous picturing of different species of animals, humans included, living in close, mutual association with one another. This move captures the city as "an entire entourage of deities and demons, animals and supernatural forces" (Barua, 2023: 102),⁵ as well as a more earthly hodgepodge of humans and other-than-humans, posing tricky questions about "who or what is to be accommodated in the city, to what extent, and why" (p. 8). A rarer definition of commensality as "eating together at the same table"⁶ is one that specifically inspires Barua, however, when speaking of "fostering relations with other-than-human life by providing food" (p. 8)—suggesting human provisioning of animals—and, in a lovely phrase, "being messmates at an urban table" (p. 21).

This is a compelling vision, at once substantive and "ethico-aesthetic" (p. 190), and there is something ennobling about the idea of a multispecies commons shared by all manner of humans and other-than-humans coming together to eat, and even assisting each other to eat, at the urban table. Nonetheless, it is hard to reconcile this vision with the dismal reality of the city as a macro-space overwhelmingly dominated by humans eating other-than-humans, housing countless tables provisioned by animals raised and slaughtered for that very purpose (historically *in* the city but now more likely elsewhere: e.g. Philo and MacLachlan, 2018). To return to the Ark, the prototype multispecies city, what the woodworm-narrator remarks is that, "[a]s far as Noah and his family were concerned, we were just a floating cafeteria" (Barnes, 2009: 14), where any non-human messmates who did make it to the table were not going to live to tell the tale. Many of the animals also had little alternative but to eat their shipmates, almost always at the direction of Noah the "admiral" (p. 14), who decided on

who should be eaten by who, in what order, and organized the spaces aboard ship accordingly. It was a commensal universe in certain respects, with plenty of eating together and humans preparing—and moving around—animals for other animals to eat, but there was little of that convivial co-dining between beings portrayed at various junctures in *Lively Cities*. I hate to raise any negativity toward Barua's book, given how creative, edifying and enlivening it is, but the downsides of a city filled with human predators—whose not-unrelated indifference toward most non-human lifeforms casually sanctions so many other, non food-related, abuses of them—cannot but signify to me a situation that is a lot more commensal (in both wider and narrower meanings of the term) for some than it is for others. I believe that much of the architecture and messaging of *Lively Cities* can, will and should survive this critique, but it remains an obvious one that, just possibly, the author should have anticipated and faced down more overtly.

In closing, I return to Julian Barnes (1984) and his experimental text *Flaubert's Parrot* about the French realist writer Gustave Flaubert (1821-1880) and a parrot called Loulou, owned by a poor, uneducated servant-woman called Félicité, the leading figure of Flaubert's novel *Un coeur simple*, who she had stuffed when he died.⁷ Seeking to track down the “real” dead parrot in question—it turns out two museums each claim to house the bird's posthumous likeness—Barnes is prompted to reconstruct in detail what he calls “Flaubert's bestiary,” meaning all Flaubert's entanglements, textual and otherwise, with animals of all sorts: bears, camels, sheep, monkeys, ostriches, dogs and parrots, alive and deceased. We hear about a fair in Guérande, “an old fortified town north-west of St Nazaire” that Flaubert visited in 1847, where he met “a five-legged sheep with a tail the size of a trumpet” (p. 45), a decidedly lively commodity from the town fair, and also a letter penned from Cairo of 1850 about “a monkey in the street” who managed to “jump on a donkey and try to wank him off” (p. 56). These sketches in *Flaubert's Parrot* suggest a crucial onto-epistemological imperative akin to that offered by Barua in *Lively Cities*: namely, to show how close-grained attentiveness always reveals previously overlooked complexity. By attending closely to the parrot—by exploring “parrotry”—something new, unexpected, arresting and diverting accrues for the scholar of Flaubert, literature and modernity. And much the same happens, majorly if in a minor key, as Barua's *Lively Cities* takes us into the contested commensalities of cities stuffed to the gunnels with humans and their other-than-human acquaintances. It is a book that should be read, re-read, taught, cited, quoted, applauded and questioned: it deserves nothing less.

Notes

1. Woodworm are the wood-eating larvae of many species of beetle. The term is also used to signal an infestation of a humanly-made wooden object, a boat or piece of furniture, and as such can be as disruptive of human “infrastructure”—an ark perhaps—as are Barua's macaques playing havoc with the powerlines above Delhi streets. Interestingly, Barua speaks of the state in terms of its bureaucratic infrastructure, suggesting that, excepting when monkeys occasionally remove state papers, this “paper state” endures and has little room for the vagaries of animal life. A little more thought about the many other-than-humans—rodents, birds and their droppings, silverfish, carpet beetles, and more—and the sustained threat that they pose to the archives of the “paper state” might nicely have complicated the story to be told here (see <https://www.archives.org.uk/collections-care-toolkit/integrated-pest-management-ipm-for-paper-archives>)
2. Others will be better-placed than me to judge, but my understanding is that Barua learns *from* the likes of Delhi as a postcolonial city—as a complex onto-epistemological object—in a manner then allowing him critically to rethink the likes of London as the “metropole” at the heart of empire. At the same time, he is counterposing the Global-Southern city—of informality, nomadism and the hospitable “cosmopolitical” gathering of humans and other-than-humans—to the very differently constituted “colonial” or “settler city” (see also Table 1).
3. One small line of critique might be that Barua's cities remain populated by a relatively limited cast of other-than-human characters. Macques, parakeets and cattle are the main players, which does lend thematic coherence across the book, but sometimes, I wanted to hear more about the countless other lifeforms and organisms constitutive of the co-mingling liveliness stressed by Barua. A curious absence, for instance, is the insect world, and I might suggest merit in reading *Lively Cities* alongside geographer Dawn Day

Biehler's (2013) superb (if perhaps neglected) *Pests in the City* with its careful tracing of “flies, bedbugs, cockroaches and rats” as urban co-dwellers often quite troublesome to “us” humans.

4. To put it very simply, *Lively Cities* is more a work of urban geography than it is one of animal geography, even if scholars with an animal geographies bent might end up being its most enthusiastic readers. It is of course also a work of both political ecology and (critical) political economy, these two perspectives being brilliantly enmeshed by Barua as he reconvenes classic Marxist (M-C-M) notations into fresh versions—enculturating and ecologising “value” in various ways—amenable to tracing the “circuits” of “lively commodities” (especially Barua, 2023: 117–124).
5. An enticing—if only sporadically—explored consideration for Barua (2023) is the imbrication of macaques and astrologists, since the latter in India sometimes “prescribe feeding macaques as a means of negating the malefic effects of astral bodies” (p. 59).
6. I have examined definitions of commensality using various sources, including <http://www.collinsdictionary.com/dictionary/english/commensality>.
7. On miscellaneous geographies of taxidermy—of “stuffing” animals—see the excellent body of work provided by Merle Patchett (2010), leading from her doctoral thesis.

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Multispecies Cities in Which Many Cities Fit

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At its most lively, Maan Barua's *Lively Cities* conveys a sense of wonder: glimpses of multispecies urban presents and futures in which we humans realize just how fortunate we are to share our cities with other living beings. This dedication to keep looking until a more colorful and fragrant image of the urbanites involved emerges will stay with me most intimately — even if, to stay with the author's terms, a minor key might bring with it sadness we often seek to avoid by quickly diverting our attention.

These are just the encounters I recall happened while reading, and reflecting, on *Lively Cities*: the Japanese striped snake who deems our small urban garden good enough to make it her home; the tiny crab, swift tadpoles and almost-grown damselfly nymph at the valley riverside; the mosquitos

welcoming my students and me in our endeavor of shoveling algae out of the pond on campus, hoping to start the process of making it a more welcoming habitat; the macaque crossing the road without a sideway glance for the cars he knows will stop; the jumping spiders practicing affective commons in our home; the unexpectedly sweet *kawachi bankan*, last citrus fruit of a miraculously long season spanning from September to June. It may also be the last fruit from this particular field feeding a human, as orchards abandoned by a rapidly aging generation of Japanese farmers without successors turn into no longer contested spaces, into posthuman edible landscapes.

In regional Japan, rural farmland and urban edges are being rewilded by more-than human presence, a “restoration of autonomous biotic and abiotic agents and processes [. . .] through the (oftentimes gradual) relinquishment of direct human management of the wild organisms or ecological processes” (Prior and Ward, 2016). Monkeys, deer, boars, and bears are exploring what might be found here, lured by leftover produce when woken hungry from a hibernation possibly shortened by climate change. State and municipality-led efforts to designate zones of human and more-than-human dwelling separated by buffers to limit encounters seem to find limited success. “The bears go where they want, they just walk along the waterways, across the fields!,” a municipal officer laments at a miniforum to discuss separating bear and human lifeworlds at the 2025 annual conference of the Japanese Institute for Landscape Architecture, organized amid rising numbers of injuries and sometimes deadly human-bear encounters. Not quite resolved to admit defeat, a participant hints at an urban world in which bears might fit—what if people knew how to live alongside bears? Yet when I ask if the bear might be one of the stakeholders whose urgent collaboration and dialogue the presenters agree is key going forward, the urban in the major key prevails: unfortunately, that would be impossible. The bears don’t speak Japanese. High time, then, for working toward interspecies dialogues.

Lively Cities joins a large ensemble of research on an expanding stage dedicated to understanding people’s views of their urban neighbors, how those urban neighbors might be looking at the world, and all the entangled facets of economies, cultures, politics and power. On the human side, early work on who we want to share our cities with is seeing renewed interest, beginning what I see as a necessary yet daunting process of mapping potential spaces of conflict and coexistence (Sweet et al., 2024). Barua rightfully draws our attention to how such work might easily be used for biopolitical ends. Yet not knowing where and why calls for extermination might arise leaves learning alongside other-than-humans to emerge wholly by chance. Research on denizenship (citizenship in a minor key?) as a mode of cohabitation likewise appears to me a fruitful conversation partner worth seeking out more thoroughly (Donaldson and Kymlicka, 2013). For more-than-humans, pioneering work is exploring what flourishing in urban spaces and futures might look like (Parker et al., 2022). Renewed interest in the sensory worlds of other species following Uexküll’s *umwelt* (Yong, 2022), only briefly touched on in *Lively Cities*, helps us understand what urban sound- and lightscapes unfold for more-than-human senses (Dominoni et al., 2020). Calls for darkness are calls for cities where insects are not caught by streetlights in spirals of doom (Fabian et al., 2024), but also for an urban sky no longer colonized by light (Nachtlichter et al., 2025). One by one, these are leaves of knowledge we might experiment with to weave diverse patterns of urban fabrics in designs for multispecies flourishing.

Taking us on a walk trying to keep up with a bovine stroll, *Lively Cities* lays out the many worlds resisting the totalizing logic of planetary urbanization. It is here that I see the book resonating with degrowth and postdevelopment. Following the Zapatista rallying call for a pluriverse (Escobar, 2018), a world in which many worlds fit, lively cities are multispecies cities in which many cities fit. I agree with Barua’s sentiment that “actually existing modes of cohabitation can in fact be far more creative and inventive than dreamt of in urban planning and theory.” Yet a core idea of degrowth is the necessity of decolonizing our (urban) imaginaries, a task we are still in the process of trying to figure out how to go about (Feola, 2019). Should we not seek to turn the sense of wonder and inspiration gained from discovering popular practices toward dreaming up planning, theory, and design as practices of political urban ontology in service of “creating avenues such that other forms of livelihoods might

flourish” (Barua) and “make kin, not cities”(Houston et al., 2017)? How might we work toward more lively cities, turning awareness of our already existing entanglements as researchers and residents into more than analysis? At moments I felt conflicted: grateful for *Lively Cities*’ patience in delicate tracing of tangled threads, yet impatient to move toward thinking through how we might apply the insights in design and action.

I return the pondering look of a local community cat, who weighs whether I might be a potential new member of the group of people she entices to feed her. In doing so, she may be constructing a niche not reliant—early GPS data suggests—on hunting wildlife in the nearby forest. In work stealing a glimpse of how and where community cats spend their time, one of my students is uncovering complex interactions with implications for municipal and conservation policies in a classic tangle of biopolitics and care. If asking for, offering, receiving, and sharing food and seats at a table are the ingredients for livelier cities, may reimagining the urban as multispecies edible landscapes (Rupprecht et al., 2023) help us widen our perspective and consider plants, insects, fungi and microbes next?

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Liveliness in the Gerrymandered City

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To comprehend its unruly complexity, humans have divided up and drawn boundaries on the city. In *Lively Cities: Reconfiguring Urban Ecology*, Maan Barua shows how animal cognition and meaning-making reframe these practices. The “lively” in *Lively Cities* refers to the sensory and semiotic facets of the boundary making of organisms. Maan describes how rhesus macaques and cattle in Delhi and

ring-necked parakeets in London make perceptual “cuts” of the city in ways that fold themselves into the affective materiality of daily urban infrastructure. But *Lively Cities* is equally about the framing or cut Maan makes of the urban, as he is an organism different only in degrees in the capacity to sift among the signs and symbols of relevance for the task taken on. The liveliness of the title then is also about the cut, the ways in which different organisms perceive, draw boundaries, interpret, and modify their environments, whether it is Barad’s agential cut that enacts reality through intra-action or Uexküll’s *Umwelt* that frames the perceptual world unique to each organism.

Lively Cities aligns with the themes of animal geographies. It contributes to an understanding of how animals are not just passive occupants contained by the city but participate in processes that give form and experiential texture to them. Maan articulates how to “register other-than-humans not simply as raw material or external agents that introduce change and modifications to economic activity but as forces that shape, steer, and constitute the economic from the outset” (p. 5). Yet this may undersell the ambition of *Lively Cities*. In addition to its contributions to urban geography, Maan’s 2023 book is also a critique of geographic thought and practice. Geography works across a continuum of views from compositional to contingent (Thrift, 1983). In compositional views, geographic entities are placed into big categories (like class, economy, biome, urban) based on the subjective quality of likeness in the phenomena within them. These categories are general and not tied to specific times or places as “form” based geography. A contextual view looks closely at what people—and for *Lively Cities*, organisms bovine, avian, and anthropoid—do in specific situations in time and place. This view focuses on relationality and interactions happening in the moment, a togetherness in a process-based view.

Maan initiates from this bottom-up “minor” contextual view of animals in the city, where the affective and material qualities of the urban arise from their mobilities, cognition, and meaning-making. This choice of framing imparts *Lively Cities* with a richer narrative about how animal geographers and animal cognition can fit into the competing show rooms of “major” geographic thought. These major theories are the “big” geographies of abstract form, like Foucault’s biopower, Marxist surplus value, or Smith’s production of nature. Maan communicates how the totalism in these ideas constrains subjects to a template, centering them within structures of thought and power with little intentionality and the capacity to resist, a critique also raised by action-theoretic scholars (Ernste, 2004). In putting action and behavior first, Maan demonstrates how animal liveliness emerges more evidently from choices negotiated in the bodies of the urban-dwelling macaques, cattle, parakeets, and humans. Instead of the big data of cell phone calls, photos in Google Earth, and word frequencies in social media, Maan gives us a glimpse of a bigger but less accessible information world, that of the sense-making of individual organisms, the minor operating within the major.

The animals in *Lively Cities* resist the interpretive yoke of biopower and capital. Maan describes how macaques and urban cattle outsmart Foucault (p. 103) and the ways in which parakeets complicate Marx (p. 118). Through ethnographic scrutiny and historical records, Maan relates how the biopolitical regulation of the animal bodies and minds through policy fails over and over in Delhi. Parakeets in London make visible how much of life in cities lies outside the domain of capital. But this is not to say the major is rejected. *Lively Cities* is a careful negotiation in how Maan conceives of the major and the minor as not oppositional. Maan argues for a contrapuntal arrangement, not a complete rejection of any major or minor “key” of geographic thought, but a diplomacy to keep both in play. This allows Maan to move each of them from background to foreground and over again. As a result, his work conveys how capital as a generative force of cities mingles with the formative power residing in embodiment, sensing, and the informational lives of animals. Maan’s cuts of the urban are positioned within the existing constellations of major key theorizing, drawing neither too close nor too far from them.

In this way, Maan metaphysically gerrymanders the city. The city becomes a modifiable boundary unit problem, a collection of interacting cuts made by humans and other animals. These cuts and their

subjective, coexisting material and sensory boundaries are leveraged by Maan as a strategy to get underneath the often shiny human surfaces of the urban. Rather than starting with a London or a Delhi corresponding to a major urban compositional form drawn from abstractions of economic and political theory, Maan backgrounds them and brings forward the minor contingent processes of how animals and their human cohort sense and respond to the shifting mosaic of affordances of the city. By doing this, Maan captures a kind of organismal non-stationarity that can unfold and complicate not only urban planning and architecture, but also academic theories, and oversimplified assumptions about the capacities of animals (De Waal, 2016).

This living spontaneity is described as “molecular” by Maan, evoking images of orbiting particles and attractions, bonds that form and break repeatedly, and materials (not just matter) interacting. Maan follows the “lines of movement” of macaques, cattle, and parakeets to document how they inhabit and modify the city. What animals do is locally attentive and inventive, adaptive, and not robotic within the outlines of major theory superimposed upon them. In Maan’s telling, animals are not an undifferentiated base or category, a generic population for ecological or municipal management. Maan’s processual-mobility view of the non-human renders more of the individual ecological character of Delhi and London. Macaques learn to track fruit vendors and the timing of offerings people make to macaques at Hindu temples (p. 71). Cows in Delhi are like ethnographers that interpret and navigate the city streets based on memory and experience (p. 198). They make their routes by establishing their own waypoints based on inferences about the predictability of food and places to rest. Maan’s cuts of the city make more visible the consequences of the more-than-human making their own cuts, that is, how they too interpret information and embed themselves in and reshape urban infrastructures. This strategy mounts a processual challenge to the sanctity of the abstracted theoretical city, one imposed hylomorphically, as a template or form, on collections of organisms and their habitats.

Lively Cities succeeds in demonstrating how animal cognition, learning, and behavior have relevance for geographic practice. We cannot think like a cow or see what the cow sees and process the information it senses in the way a cow would. But we as humans have the capacity to step outside ourselves to describe it (De Waal, 2016). Maan conveys how the information that a cow, a macaque, or parakeet senses and acts upon may not be apparent or directly accessible to us. Instead, it is the medium—the body of the animal—that is the message. Interpretation emerges through this embodied medium, with all of its mysteries and surprise, rather than through any unambiguous and direct access to free-floating data. As one of several examples in the book, macaques perceive the daily rhythms of Hindu practices and time their activity with the movements of people so as to more likely procure handouts of fruit. This process-event is traceable only in the behavior of the macaques and not in any elaboration about how macaques think or see and make inferences about when it is advantageous to come out and be seen. Lively cities have an invisibility in that this meaning-making cannot be perceived directly, but only inferred through the bodies and actions of organisms. It is, in a sense, similar to Kwan’s (2012) uncertain geographic context problem of inferring the exact cause or motivation for any individual’s movement and position in space.

But it is not all ceaseless flow of informational signs and semiosis in Maan’s cities. Maan acknowledges the phenomenological stickiness that allows the durability of forms to materialize. He relates how rural forms, spaces, and places persist in Delhi through cattle and urban dairies. Through their natural intelligence and the affordances presented to them, cattle embed the rural into the urban by making paths and establishing resting areas. Municipal governance then attempts to convert this rural back to urban through policies to restrict and control cattle. This imbrication of the urban and rural in the city is in relational flux but has a durability that arises through the phenomenological experience of cattle (and also humans) as they learn paths that lead to food, water, and quiet. Maan employs this relational phenomenology (Ingold, 2011) to balance processual openness with how embodied perceptions and behaviors can be transformed into niches of predictable form—that is, dependable browse if you are a cow, or where there are plenty of temple worshipers to buy and give you fruit if you are a macaque.

Lively Cities scores several small but strategic points that reconcile geography with ideas from the life sciences. This is geography as biology rather than a geography as a study of biology or biological issues impacting humans. *Lively Cities* positions itself at a boundary where some concepts from evolution and ecology move across the membrane separating it from geography, while geographical ideas are allowed to move in the other direction. As one example, while the rhizomes of Deleuze get a lot of metaphorical mileage in geography, Maan gives us a graphical Deleuzian phylogeography of the lively capital of the escaped individuals of London's ring-necked parakeet (p. 132). It sits alongside ecology and evolution's now long-standing use of the rhizome metaphor as one of the patterns of the evolution of life (Doolittle, 1999), a recognition not done by citing Deleuze but by mapping genomic relationships among different life forms.

As a second example, instead of defaulting only to the competitive or predatory struggle to survive as the foundation of humans and animal interactions in the city, Maan prioritizes a neutral to positive ecological interaction, commensality, to characterize their relationality. Humans and animals in the city are not portrayed as unrealistically devoid of any negative, destructive interactions. Instead, Maan conveys how these negative interactions arise as a result of their coming together in commensal encounters. Commensality operates as an attracting infrastructure (p. 49) that establishes the relational substrate upon which antagonisms and negative interactions later emerge. This resonates with a long line of ecological perspectives, like Lynn Margulis's theory of symbiosis and the philosophical and critical positions advanced by Isabella Stengers and Donna Haraway. They each emphasize a constitutive role for positive or enabling relations, but do not give them primacy in a totalizing way. To illustrate this for macaques, Maan reviews the history of how these monkeys moved into Delhi (again) in more recent decades in response to their capture and commerce for the medical trade in outlying areas. Food was available in markets and as alms, and the improvisationally-built electrical infrastructure of the city was conducive to macaque mobility. These commensal interaction of humans and macaques in Delhi had the potential within them to shift negative, which as Maan relates can range from macaques causing power outages (and getting electrocuted), boarding trains, occupying airport terminals, turning on (but less often turning off) public water taps, destroying electrical meters (for which humans get blamed), causing traffic jams, stealing and holding human belongings for ransom, and in one instance even contributing to a balcony fall and subsequent death of the deputy mayor of Delhi.

One of several questions I have is whether the liveliness Maan describes for the city is only contained there. Cognition and agential cuts, affect and habit, and meaning-making by organisms may be more visible in the city, but the city is just a stand in for the larger field of play that is any place on Earth. Another question is why and how the major comes to dominate. Does major theory and its dominance arise out of the very qualities of the minor? What qualities and motivations differentiate the minor boundary making of non-human life forms from the boundary making of human theorists? Finally, to what extent can Maan's arc of argument mesh with the emergence of the first human cities? Did they begin in Maan's minor key through the contingent scaling up of local molecular meaning-making among early members of the genus *Homo* and accompanying animals (and plants, as well as many other life forms) with their own attentive affordances? If so, was it this relationality, as a commensal prior, rather than the forces of political and economic major theories, that set cities into motion?

My questions reflect how *Lively Cities* gestures toward a geography made robust through attentiveness to more-than-human lives. A robust geography, in my opinion, is one that can operate across all living forms, and not just as a geography for and about extant humans. Maan clearly sympathizes with the idea that we should judge a theory insofar as it can offer logical linkages to the more-than-human:

"A serious engagement with other than humans, on the other hand, points to the inadequacy of theory in a major key, for the latter falls apart when the actions, desires, and potentials of a retinue of beings are brought into the fray" (p. 280)

Finally, Maan's breadth and grasp of geographic ideas ensures that *Lively Cities* is not a reductionist book, one that hews to a few critical-minded scholars who read from the same bookshelf and aspire to detail the filigrees of difference among themselves. Marua's book is far more of a synthesis. This may challenge readers who have not had enough time to accumulate a more-than-seminar familiarity of geographic thought. *Lively Cities* is a reflection on seeing and comprehending in a world that is gerrymandered and gerrymandering because of the properties of life. Maan promotes a healthy problematization of not just the urban but also of geography. As Maan states in the last sentence of the book (p 291) ". . .to write the urban in a minor key is not to lament, for the minor gives us the greatest arsenal of all: the power of thinking and acting otherwise."

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The Urban in a Minor Key

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My aim in *Lively Cities* was to argue that the urban is not simply a container within which relations between people, institutions, living beings, materials and infrastructure unfold, as much scholarship on nonhuman life in cities vies toward. Rather, these relations themselves forge what we come to know as urbanity. The book insists that the urban varies historically, materially and politically, and these variations ought to be at the heart of a comparative project, where locales in the Global South and North might be read alongside one another to show how cities diverge. Underlining these imperatives is a methodological effort to elicit other-than-human worlds—however partially such worlds are knowable. *Lively Cities* draws posthumanist, political economic and postcolonial traditions into conversation, and by doing so, foregrounds another politics of city-making not necessarily discernible when only one of these approaches is chosen. It is, after all, a book with strange interlocutors that do not map on to the usual suspects animating urban theory. Readers may suddenly confront interlocutors as jokers, at other times thieves, all trying to find some way out of a situation that is not always of their own making.

All of the interventions in this forum are careful and generous engagements with *Lively Cities*—what more could an author ask for? But, in the spirit of this conversation, let me address a few important points that the interventions raise, and which I believe require greater intellectual investment in the future.

A first set pertains to what a widened ontology of the urban does. Alicia Barceinas Cruz draws attention to the nanoscopic virus that reconfigured not just everyday urban life during the Covid-19 pandemic, but also spatial organization, social and economic relations—whose effects have long outlasted the pandemic's formal end. I am grateful for the generosity of their engagement with a book written during that very moment, and for their reminder of the many more mutinies of this kind that pattern urban life.

Questions of what beings, materials and relations write the urban also return. Chris Philo—whose work with Chris Wilbert on “beastly places” has been pivotal to my own thinking (Philo and Wilbert, 2000)—draws out conceptual operations in ways far better than I could manage myself. Their comment, in the second footnote, that I learn from cities like Delhi to rethink London, is exactly right. I am also very sympathetic to their generative observation that *Lively Cities* emphasizes some modes of eating over others—those dependent on death and slaughter find little mention. Those who do not become commensal, who are consumed, do not live to tell their tale. Or perhaps, their tale must be read through death. This is, in fact, the subject of my current work on urban metabolism, which turns to industrially produced animals to rethink many of the questions posed in *Lively Cities* in a more visceral register. Philo’s lines of thought are extremely helpful for such a project where aliveness is only part of the story.

J Anthony Stallins and others draw attention to the more-than-human ethnography at stake. In *Lively Cities*, my endeavor has been to think from observant participation—as a means of engaging with the urban by remaining within it, not by taking oneself out of it (Ingold, 2000; Thrift, 2000). And while animals are not ethnographers—in that they do not write up findings—they too are observant participants of the same world humans inhabit. Their survival depends on it. These are elements of a more-than-human ethnography that I seek to distinguish from the more popular “multispecies” label (also see: Ingold, 2014). The subject of inquiry here shifts from species to assemblage. If the pace and montage of the text feel disorienting or “giddy,” it is partly because the emphasis on assemblage—rather than dyadic multispecies relations of human/animal/plant/microbe—pulls both the writer and the reader in multiple directions at once. In lived experience, much of this recedes into the background or is sensed corporeally. But to written in a vein where the background continually becomes foreground is to take readers on a journey where a lot is happening at once. If there is one thing cities do not lack, it is sensation.

If *Lively Cities* feels abstract in places, I would say that such abstractions are necessary—otherwise the text risks becoming an idiographic dead end. This is also the power of thinking from different locales: abstractions produced in one setting—say the Global South—should not be a parochial explanation of that context alone. Rather, they should help us understand how it diverges from another context and how it brings new interpretations into view elsewhere. One could think of squatting as a widespread urban condition, or reading capital from waste rather than value, as two generative avenues for reading the urban that abstractions from the Global South have prised open (Bhan, 2019). Such abstractions, I also hope, are warm abstractions (McCormack, 2012), in that they sit alongside the concrete which might appear strange in its richness.

Another theme concerns where the urban lies. Stallins is munificent in noting that the text allows different durabilities of spatial form to materialize, and they push this argument in exactly the direction it should go: why bind inquiry to the traditional remit of the city when urbanization—lively or otherwise—occurs across a wider terrain (also see: Bathla, 2024)? This question animates my current work, including a book manuscript that aims to think of urbanization from wetlands rather than the built environment on which much urban theory is based. And if life has always been more-than-human (cf. Whatmore, 2004), how might we think of cities beyond the human, even in the earliest of settlements? Stallins’ provocations can in fact lead to new lines of inquiry, where urban theory might work more closely with archeology—a discipline that has a lot to say about such questions.

Each of the interventions touch on politics. Christoph D.D. Rupprecht is spot on when they ask how might the politics invoked in the text move beyond diagnosis to forms of praxis such diagnosis might serve. Along with others, I have retained a healthy skepticism of tendencies in the social sciences that expect politics to suddenly emerge when Cartesian binaries between Nature and Society are dissolved. As Rupprecht aptly points out, the politics espoused in *Lively Cities* is grounded in the actions of those who inhabit the lived city. Giving directions to these actions for a broader political program requires far more than what an academic book can provide. I highlight minor

practices—often operating below the thresholds of detectability—precisely because their protagonists avoid open confrontation. As Stallins evocatively puts it, this is a matter of gerrymandering the city: altering the boundaries of action, of what constitutes community, and of what is granted power to act. But giving such energies direction—beyond the remit of what is practiced—requires making them “major” in some way—orienting them not toward some quiet mutiny as a model of action, even though that is how many cope with growing precarity, but targeting structural inequalities that make minor practices necessary in the first place.

We are in a world steeped in a widening polycrisis, where habitability is being eroded, and the urban is being reshaped for the worse, not for the better. These concerns are what I take up in my more recent ethnography of urban wetlands and research on urban metabolism. Just as *Lively Cities* urges for moves beyond the major, and calls for being critical of positions that claim to know solutions in advance—whether in theory or practice—one must exercise the same skepticism toward one’s own proposals. *Lively Cities* and the motley crowd it gathers can only do so much. The generative readings provided by Alicia Barceinas Cruz, Chris Philo, Christoph D. D. Rupprecht, and J. Anthony Stallins offer ways of expanding thought, engagement and practice. There must be some way out of here.

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